This approach aligns naturally with Zero Trust principles. Rather than assuming a system will behave as expected, each action is verified in real time based on current conditions.

18.3.4 Practical implications

In practice, embedding authorization in the agent loop has several important effects:

- **Continuous enforcement**—Every action is checked before it executes, not just at system entry points.
- **Dynamic adaptability**—Policies apply even when the agent's behavior changes from one execution to another.
- **Clear operational boundaries**—Agents can explore freely within defined limits but cannot exceed them.
- **Behavioral feedback**—Denials inform the agent's planning process, shaping its approach to a task.

These properties enable safe deployment of agents in environments where they interact with sensitive data and critical systems.

At ACME, this architecture enabled agents to access enterprise tools, analyze data, and automate workflows while remaining subject to the same policy framework that governed employees and applications. Agents were not treated as a special case. They became another class of principal operating within the organization's authorization system.

The result is a system where flexibility and control coexist. Agents retain the ability to plan and adapt, but every action they take is constrained by policy. Authorization is integral to the agent's operation, not merely an external safeguard.